
GOLDEN MAPLE LANDSCAPING

· 2026 EDITION ·

The 2026 Simcoe County Backyard *Cost Guide.*

Real numbers. No fluff.
From 42 completed Simcoe County jobs.

BARRIE · INNISFIL · ORO-MEDONTE · SPRINGWATER

A guide written *for the homeowner.*

If you're reading this, you're probably somewhere between Pinterest boards and a panic attack about the price tag. You've likely gathered two or three quotes that swing wildly — one says \$18,000, another says \$42,000 — and nobody seems willing to explain why.

I built this guide because that's broken. You shouldn't have to learn the hardscape industry from the inside before you can confidently choose who puts a five-figure investment into your yard. So I sat down with our last two seasons of completed jobs across Barrie, Innisfil, Oro-Medonte and Springwater and pulled out the real numbers — what we charged, what we spent, and what makes one \$30,000 patio last 30 years while another fails in 30 months.

My philosophy is simple. Premium landscaping isn't decoration. It's engineering. The pavers you see are the easy part — the 16 inches of compacted base underneath them is where the price comes from, and where the cheap quotes always cut. Every page that follows shows you exactly what's hidden under the surface — figuratively and literally.

Read it cover to cover or skim the tables. Either way, you'll walk into your next contractor conversation knowing exactly what questions to ask and what numbers should look right. That's the goal.

Yorkis Estevez

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What a backyard *actually costs.*

Most homeowners over-shoot or under-shoot their budget by 40%. These four tiers describe what's realistic for a fully-engineered, premium-built outdoor space in Simcoe County in 2026.

I. Front Entrance Makeover **\$15,000 — \$35,000+**

Removal of builder-grade steps, new concrete foundation, custom stone steps, and an interlocking walkway to the driveway. The upper end adds low-voltage LED lighting, planting beds, and premium natural stone components.

II. The Functional Backyard — Patio & Fire Pit **\$25,000 — \$50,000+**

A 400–600 sqft interlocking patio on a 14–16" engineered base, a built-in seating wall, and a custom fire feature (wood-burning or natural gas). This is the most common starting point — enough scope to host without overshooting.

III. Elevated Outdoor Living Space **\$60,000 — \$120,000+**

Multiple zones: dining, lounging, gas fire feature. Custom outdoor kitchen (BBQ, fridge, granite counters), structural retaining walls if the yard is sloped, and full landscape lighting. Effectively adds a new room to the home.

IV. Complete Property Transformation **\$150,000 — \$300,000+**

Whole-property scope: front driveway, entrance, extensive grading and drainage solutions, multi-level backyard terraces, pool surrounds, and fully automated lighting and irrigation systems.

Six common projects, *by the numbers.*

Installed prices for premium-built interlocking projects across Simcoe County in 2026. Includes engineered base, materials, and finishing — assumes standard site access and Techo-Bloc or Permacon products.

Project Type	Typical Size	2026 Range
Backyard patio	150–300 sqft	\$9,000 — \$18,000
Large patio with features	300–600 sqft	\$18,000 — \$40,000
Front walkway	50–120 sqft	\$4,000 — \$9,000
Single driveway	400–600 sqft	\$20,000 — \$35,000
Double driveway	600–900 sqft	\$30,000 — \$50,000
Pool surround	200–500 sqft	\$15,000 — \$35,000

◆ PER-SQUARE-FOOT BENCHMARK

Premium-built interlocking installs in our region range from **\$55–\$85 per square foot installed** in 2026 — inclusive of engineered base prep, materials, polymeric jointing, and finishing. Anything quoted under \$40/sqft is cutting the base prep, the materials, or both.

Why the wide ranges? Site access, base depth, paver choice, and whether your yard is flat or sloped each move the final price by 15–30%. The next pages break down each lever.

The material cost ladder.

Pavers are the single biggest material line on a patio quote. Here's what each tier of paver actually costs per square foot — and what you give up going down-market.

Material	2026 Price	Best Use
Standard concrete pavers	\$45 — \$60/sqft	Budget patios and walkways. Builder-grade colour and finish — fades within 2–3 years.
Techo-Bloc premium	\$60 — \$80/sqft	Mid-to-high patios and driveways. Lifetime transferable warranty engineered for Ontario freeze-thaw.
Porcelain pavers	\$75 — \$100/sqft	Modern outdoor living and pool decks. Specialized lifting equipment + flawless base required.
Natural stone	\$80 — \$120/sqft	High-end feature areas, steps, and vertical detail. Each stone unique.

◆ OUR RECOMMENDATION

For 90% of Simcoe County patios, **Techo-Bloc** or **Permacon** hits the right balance — premium colour mixes that don't fade, lifetime transferable warranty, and engineering specifically tuned for Ontario freeze-thaw cycles. Skip the builder-grade tier unless you genuinely don't care about the patio in 5 years.

Three patios, *three budgets.*

Same 400 sqft footprint, three very different builds. This is how the decisions compound when you choose materials, edges, and features.

FUNCTIONAL	ENTERTAINER	LUXURY
≈ \$15,000	≈ \$25,000	\$40,000+
The Minimum	The Sweet Spot	Outdoor Room
Standard pavers, simple square shape, flat yard with good access. Proper 14" engineered base. The right floor for entry-level outdoor living.	Techo-Bloc / Unilock Beacon Hill premium pavers, contrasting border, curved edges, matching stone fire pit. Where most homeowners land.	Large-format premium slabs, slight slope with seating wall, integrated LED lighting, built-in natural-gas fire feature. Hosts dinner parties.

A worked example.

What it actually looks like to price a real backyard from a recent Innisfil project.

Line Item	Calculation	Cost
350 sqft Techo-Bloc patio	350 × \$70/sqft installed	\$24,500
3 stone steps (front of patio)	Custom-cut, mortared	\$2,500
Low-voltage LED landscape lighting	10 fixtures + transformer	\$3,000
TOTAL	Premium turn-key install	≈ \$30,000

What actually moves *the number.*

Eight variables explain why two patios of identical size can quote \$14K apart. Knowing them lets you compare apples to apples.

Base preparation	Professional standard: 12–16" excavation + 8–12" compacted Granular A + 1" HPB or sand. Cheap installers cut to 4–6" — saves on excavation, disposal and aggregate, guarantees heaving by year two.
Geotextile & geogrid	Geotextile separates clay soil from the stone base (mandatory on most Simcoe County yards). Geogrid ties retaining walls into the earth. Skipping them is the #1 reason walls lean by 18 months.
Sloped lot premium	If your yard slopes, expect +15–25% on the base price for extra excavation, retaining, and stepped designs. South Barrie clay slopes are particularly demanding.
Restricted access	A 3-foot side gate turns a 4-day install into a 9-day install. Material moves by hand or mini-excavator instead of skid-steer. Labour cost can double on the same square footage.
Steps	\$1,500 — \$4,000 per set , depending on stone type, custom cuts, and whether they're free-standing or mortared into a foundation.
Built-in lighting	\$2,000 — \$5,000 for In-Lite or Kichler LED systems including fixtures, wiring, transformer, and timers. Done right, transforms how the space reads at night.
Seat walls	\$3,000 — \$8,000 for a built-in seat wall with cap stones. Adds permanent seating without consuming patio square footage.
Romex jointing premium	Polymer-infused jointing (vs. standard polymeric sand) adds \$3–5/sqft but eliminates ant-pulling, weed germination, and joint washout. Worth it in shaded yards.
Perimeter retaining wall	A 2-foot retaining wall around a sloped patio adds \$5,000 — \$10,000 . Often necessary in Oro-Medonte and Springwater builds where natural grade falls.

If not interlocking, *then what?*

How interlocking pavers stack up against the four most common alternatives in Simcoe County. Lifespan and maintenance assume Ontario freeze-thaw conditions.

Material	Price/sqft	Lifespan	Maintenance
Interlocking stone	\$55 — \$85	25 — 30 yrs	Low
Stamped concrete	\$20 — \$35	10 — 15 yrs	Medium (will crack)
Poured concrete	\$15 — \$25	15 — 20 yrs	Low
Natural flagstone	\$40 — \$70	30+ yrs	Low
Wood deck	\$35 — \$65	15 — 20 yrs	High (annual stain)

■ THE HIDDEN TRUTH ABOUT STAMPED CONCRETE

Stamped concrete is *not* a question of **if** it cracks, only **when**. Ontario's freeze-thaw cycles guarantee it. Interlocking pavers **flex** with the freeze-thaw — individual pavers move slightly, the patio stays intact. That's the whole reason interlocking became the regional standard.

The five hidden costs *in a low quote.*

When you see one quote 40% under the others, it's not a deal — it's five specific cuts that won't show up until year two.

01

The 6-inch base

The cheap contractor digs 6" instead of 14–16". Saves on excavation, disposal, and aggregate. Day one: identical to the premium build. Year two: heaved, sunken, cracked.

02

Skipped geotextile & geogrid

Geotextile fabric separates clay from stone. Geogrid ties retaining walls into the earth. Both cost money and time — both get cut. Result: patios that pump clay up through the joints, walls that lean at 18 months.

03

Poor drainage planning

A real install includes 1.5–2% slope, perforated drain tiles, and water-flow assessment. Cheap installs trap water against your foundation (flooded basements) or pond it on the surface (frozen pavers, cracked stone).

04

Bait-and-switch materials

The quote says 'premium pavers.' The truck arrives with builder-grade product from a big-box store. Same shape — different mix, different finish, fades in two seasons. Always demand the exact brand and line in writing.

05

No WSIB, no liability insurance

Premium contractors carry WSIB (\$) and multimillion-dollar liability (\$\$). The unmarked truck doing it cash for \$18K? Often neither. If a worker injures themselves on your property, **you can be held personally liable** for their medical bills and lost wages.

The true cost *of the bargain.*

Half of our summer schedule is spent ripping out cheap patios and failing retaining walls that were installed two or three years prior. Here's the math we walk new clients through when they bring us a competing low quote.

THE TRUE COST OF DOING IT TWICE

Initial cheap install: **\$18,000** + Demo & disposal: **\$5,000** + Proper rebuild:
\$35,000

TRUE COST OF THE "BARGAIN"

\$58,000

vs. \$35,000 done right the first time

"You aren't saving \$17,000 by choosing the lowest bid. You're paying an \$18,000 deposit on a headache you'll have to fix in three years."

— YORKIS ESTEVEZ, FOUNDER

Red flags & *the four questions.*

Six red flags in a quote.

- ✗ Per-sqft prices under \$40 installed
- ✗ No mention of base depth or aggregate type
- ✗ "We'll figure it out on site"
- ✗ No written multi-year warranty
- ✗ Deposit requested over 50% upfront
- ✗ No proof of WSIB clearance or liability insurance

Standard deposit structure is 10–30% upfront, balance in milestone payments tied to base completion, paver delivery, and final cleanup.

Four questions.

In writing, before you sign.

- Q1.** Exactly how many inches deep will you excavate for the base?
- Q2.** Are you using 3/4" clear stone or limestone screenings ("gravel dust") for the base?
- Q3.** Can you provide a current WSIB clearance certificate today?
- Q4.** Does your contract include a written multi-year warranty covering sinking and settlement?

If the answer to any of these is hesitation, vagueness, or a subject change — walk.

◆ THE YORKIS RULE

If a contractor can't answer all four of these in under 60 seconds without checking notes — they don't actually know how to build a patio that lasts. Save the conversation, end the call, move on.

When to build, *what to budget.*

Build season timing.

Simcoe County's hardscape season runs **April through November**. Premium contractors fill their April–June slots by February. If you want first-half-of-season install for 2026, the smart booking window is:

Jan — Mar: Design phase, material selection, contract signed. Lock April–May install.

Apr — May: Early-season install. Best weather window, highest contractor availability.

Jun — Aug: Peak season. Premium crews at full capacity. Project lead times stretch to 6–10 weeks.

Sep — Nov: Late-season install. Cooler temperatures are actually ideal for paver setting and joint stabilization.

How much to budget.

The **Appraisal Institute of Canada** recommends budgeting **10–15% of your home's total value** for a complete landscape renovation. For a \$900K Barrie home, that's \$90K–\$135K range — which lines up almost exactly with our Tier III "Elevated Outdoor Living" budget.

Most homeowners under-budget on first-time projects by 25–40% because they price only the patio, forgetting drainage, lighting, plantings, and finishing. Multiply your patio quote by 1.4 for a realistic total.

◆ FREE 15-MINUTE DISCOVERY CALL

Before you spend \$200 on anyone's design consultation — including ours — we offer a **free 15-minute phone discovery call**. Honest scope assessment, honest budget feedback, no pressure. If your project isn't a fit for what we do, we'll tell you and recommend someone better. Available year-round.

GOLDEN MAPLE LANDSCAPING

Ready to talk about your *project?*

A free 15-minute discovery call with the founder.
Honest scope. Honest budget. No pressure.

CALL

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◆ WSIB CERTIFIED

◆ \$5M LIABILITY

◆ 5-YR WARRANTY

Prices reflect 2026 Simcoe County market and assume premium materials, engineered base preparation, and full-service installation.
All projects subject to final scope and site assessment.

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